Rough Seas; Better Navigation

The waves grow higher, and the wind beats upon your drenched and freezing body. You cower at the fate that awaits you as you row to no avail, pulling your helpless vessel toward the opposite shore. The fear of capsizing is now very real.

The disciples must have been terrified.

Mark says, “The waves beat into the ship, so that it was now full.”

The apostles’ feet, sopping wet. Their knees, below water. Treading the water as they moved. Hoping and trying not to lose sight of their mission.

I imagine the thought of the experienced sailor was to weather the storm through will and strength. I assume it was a secondary thought, or even a final desperate moment, that brought to mind a sleeping Savior upon the very vessel believed to be in danger.

> *“He was in the hinder part of the ship, asleep on a pillow: and they awake him, and say unto him, Master, carest thou not that we perish?”*

I would assume that one has to be near death to ask the future Savior of the world, whom these gentlemen are choosing to follow till the end, a question like “Carest not that we perish?” I mean, certainly, they have seen miracles, and they are asking the calm and collected, all-powerful one if he was worried?

Well, I would be scared too. If I were an experienced sailor, fishing for my livelihood, and suddenly found myself caught in a storm so incredibly tumultuous that Mark would call it a furious squall that broke into their boat.

Although, my guess is that, more likely, I'd be the garment-soaked note taker, clutching my deteriorating parchment at the bow of the ship, whilst clamoring for a foothold to steady myself against the swells as the seafaring others attempted in vain to level our creaking transport.

Either way, this crew of seasoned fishermen and trembling newbies cried out to the Creator of the universe.

I'd be quite frustrated too if the one I knew could quiet the storm slept idly by, as if there were a summer's rain tapping gently on the window in the peaceful afternoon.

And to be completely honest, the thought that the Savior is sleeping on my ship while I weather a storm gives me pause.

If I am straining at the mast and the Master of all the earth is peacefully riding along, maybe I need not worry. At least, not to such an extent.

But, in the moment, I realize that is not fair to the apostles aboard the ship. I more than sympathize with their plight.

I too would cry out. And amidst my trials, I admit that not quite often enough, I too shout and even plead with my Savior to see me and save me.

The combination of waves and tears soaked wood, failing strength, and torn sails lay tempest-tossed and surely on a path to destruction.

But, aboard the vessel, sleeping through it: a Savior, a man, a God, a master teacher, and element tamer, Christ the Lord.

> *"And he arose, and rebuked the wind, and said unto the sea,*

Peace, be still.

And the wind ceased, and there was a great calm."

"You of little faith, why are you so afraid?"

In other words, "Really, guys? You woke me up 'cause there was rain?"

We all face storms in life. Whether they be temporary or long-lasting. An impending destruction or a minor inconvenience. A trial or a lifestyle. Our storms will beat upon us as did the waves of the apostles' physical and literal storm they faced that night.

Christ is with us though, and we need not fear. The Lord of heaven and earth will weather any storm and rest His weary head on any vessel on which He feels welcome to board.

And if it be His will, sometimes He may even step in and calm the sea.

Life can seem unfair at times.

Why did my friend have a doctor who cured her brother of his cancer, while my cousin still goes in for regular scans for cancer?

Why do all the malnourished kids, with their parasites and singular pair of shoes, in villages I spent a fraction of my life in whilst serving a mission, remain as they are, while there are rich and famous in Maui this weekend? Or, closer to home, why do they live in squalor while we sit in a classroom turned chapel, in a room we sometimes complain gets overheated in the winter?

Can the Lord calm the storms of those we see in suffering? Did the others who crossed the sea before the apostles reach the other side and look back to see them

mid-journey as a storm approached overhead, and turn to their left and to their right to say something like,

“I hope they make it”?

Is the Lord even on the boat?

Is there a reason I can believe that such suffering, as those plagued by war and famished by the travails of mortality, can be left to wander this life rowing a boat whose sails have torn and rudder snapped?

Where is the outstretched hand of the Savior to calm their seas? When I find life a bit too hard to handle, where is my Lord of Hosts?

Care he not that I perish?

“Peace, be still” was bade the storm.

Why so faithless? Why so scared? The apostles were rebuked.

Does the Savior let us suffer? Or does He sleep to show us that the storm will pass?

Maybe taking away the storm is only helpful when the Lord needs us to stop focusing on mortality and listen to reality, or rather, eternal reason.

For most of us, the storm itself brings the lesson. The storm is a trial, a test, and a season. It will pass and leave behind a better disciple. The Savior sleeps because He knows it will. He fears not; He is at peace. He is still.

Turning now to our study of Joseph Smith—History:

Joseph Smith wrote about his storm:

> *“In the midst of this war of words and tumult of opinions, I often said to myself: What is to be done? Who of all these parties are right; or, are they all wrong together? If any one of them be right, which is it, and how shall I know it?”*

Every church and Bible-bashing preacher was another wave that beat upon Joseph and his frail and groaning vessel.

Every foul word spoken or screaming so-called saint who deemed themselves a better Christian than their neighbor was another frigid wind upon the sea.

Joseph Smith was rowing a boat and trying to bring it in to shore, but was caught in a storm he could not navigate through.

So he cried out.

> *“I kneeled down and began to offer up the desires of my heart to God. I had scarcely done so, when immediately I was seized upon by some power which entirely overcame me, and had such an astonishing influence over me as to bind my tongue so that I could not speak. Thick darkness gathered around me, and it seemed to me for a time as if I were doomed to sudden destruction.”*

Joseph was in the midst of a storm that was building, and as we can see with the Church in existence today, his battle was only at its beginning in the grove of trees.

Joseph said:

> *“My object in going to inquire of the Lord was to know which of all the sects was right, that I might know which to join.*

I was answered that I must join none of them, for they were all wrong;"

Notice that the Lord did not remove the churches that were berating the young prophet.

His storm was not removed. His seas were not calmed.

Often. And I would say more oft than not, we pray that our storm be put to rest, but what we get is an eternal navigation system.

In the case of Joseph Smith, he asked for calmer seas, but the Lord provided a direction in which to sail.

God appointed him captain and gave him a compass and charged him with the guidance of the vessel of generations of faithful Latter-day Saints back to their Heavenly Father.

Each and every day, our storm-beaten hearts and minds cry out to our peaceful, still, and faithful Savior, asking Him for a life of peace and tranquility.

But Jesus captains our ship for us far too often.

Sometimes He has to let us steer, and He will stand and guide. Even if that guidance looks like showing us that you can have peace amidst a tempest.

We will weather many a storm to come.

Rougher seas are ahead.

We will only be able to sail through the next and bigger storm if we accept the Lord's guidance and a better navigation system. We practice on the smaller swells to break through the life-altering, gut-wrenching trials of tomorrow. But

the Savior will board your vessel if you let Him, and ride with you till you make it home.

Take heart. The sea calms eventually. Because Jesus is the great helmsman of our souls.

If we choose to be faithful through our storms, they will pass over us, and we will sail to calmer waters.

Ask God to calm the storm, but do not be surprised when He hands you a better compass than the one you have and names you captain.

I say in the name of the great and true compass, Jesus Christ, amen.